

STORYTELLING IN THE ENGLISH CLASSROOM: EXPERIENCE OF TRAINING SESSIONS FOR TEACHERS

Olha Sushkevych

PhD, Associate professor,

*Pavlo Tychyna Uman State Pedagogical University
28, Sadova str., Uman, Ukraine*

Abstract

The paper discusses the growing significance of storytelling as a representation tool for individuals and companies, emphasizing its role in communicative success or failure. It introduces a session conducted at Pavlo Tychyna Uman State Pedagogical University and Sumy State Pedagogical University (Ukraine) in October 2023, aimed at enhancing the English teaching staff's storytelling skills. The primary objective was to develop and refine methods and techniques for working with text and components of written and oral storytelling. The focus of the sessions was on understanding crucial elements of a story, such as characters, place, events, conflict, author-audience dynamics, and their embodiment in the text.

Keywords: storytelling, classroom, educators, communicative success, communicati failure.

Nowadays storytelling has become alike a business card of a person or a company. It is a marker of failures or successes in communication (1; 2). We deal with storytelling daily starting from routine small talks about our affairs ending up with significant projects, which reveal the image of our activities and ourselves (3; 4). Respectively, the skill of developing storytelling is gradually introduced in the English classroom starting from small dialogues and narratives, and ending up

with thematic projects and stories of various genres (1). This paper presents a session specially designed for both English teaching staff to master their professional skills of facilitating and developing storytelling with the students whose level of English is advanced. This session was realized at Pavlo Tychyna Uman State Pedagogical University and Sumy State Pedagogical University named after A. S. Makarenko (Ukraine) in October 2023.



Illustration 1.

Students and staff of the Faculty of Foreign Languages (USPU) with their short stories after the training session.

The purpose of the session is to develop and improve the methods and techniques of working with text and components of written and oral storytelling.

The first step of the session procedure involves the focus on the classic structure of the story development given below. The main point is to analyze what elements are crucially important for a story and what parameters it involves (e.g. characters, place, events, conflict; the interplay of the author and audience; communicative and pragmatic embodiment of these issues in

the text, etc.). The participants of the session are suggested a range of Wh-questions to brainstorm ideas about these elements of writing (e.g. What is the life story behind the character's face? What are his biggest fears? Why are you together now? etc.). Besides, the students and staff are given a wide choice of possible places and people to choose for their stories. They also enjoy full freedom to develop the plots the way they prefer.

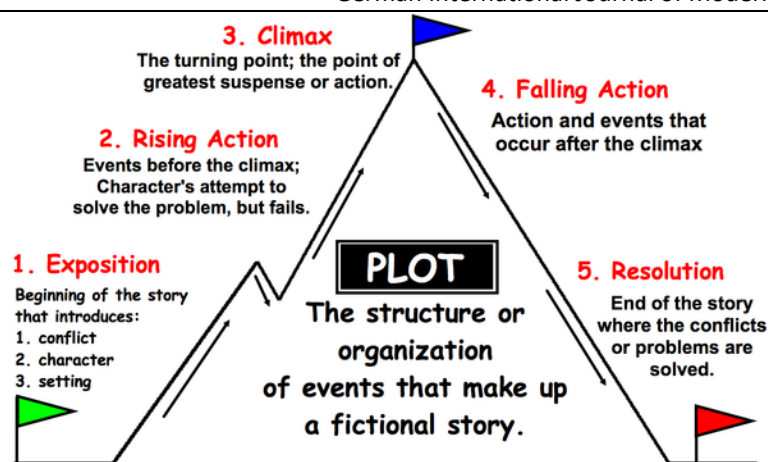


Illustration 2. The classical structure of a story

During this stage, the participants of the session are suggested to focus their attention on the creative personality of the writer, who works on a series of short stories and is currently experiencing a creative crisis. The teaching staff is asked to analyze the factors that could affect the writer's burnout, as well as how to help get out of such a crisis as if helping a student to get involved in a story development.

The second step of the session presupposes brainstorming concerning the quality and attractiveness of the story and how to facilitate the students to develop the ability to create bright characters, descriptions of the place of action / unfolding events, and dialogues between heroes. The combination of visual, oral, physical, audial, and sensual is highly recommended (i.e. some students can contribute to the story with their illustrations, others with narration, performing skills, or analysis, etc.). Thus, the participants of the seminar can be asked to choose the roles of "an illustrator", "a narrator", "a compiler of dialogues", "a historian" or "a character". According to his status, everyone has the opportunity to participate in the development of the story according to its classical structure. Thus, the students can be involved in cooperative activities and reveal their skills and abilities.

At this stage, the faculty and students have the opportunity to cooperate in the creative process of storytelling, choosing the main and secondary characters, the places where the events evolve, the main conflict and ways to resolve it, as well as participating in the creation of non-intersecting dialogues between the characters. This phase of the session reveals students' cooperative skills and teachers' ability to facilitate the whole process for the sake of creating unprecedented stories.

At the next stage, the teachers' function is to coordinate story editing, making them coherent and cohesive, and generally flow well. They joined their efforts with the students to compose a full-fledged story.

In the end, each team had the opportunity to present their story orally and act it out in front of the audience.

The session ended with a summary of the developed activities and an exchange of opinions regarding the use of the proposed activities and tasks when working with students.

In conclusion, we would like to provide the feedback received from Olena Bahatska (SSPU) after the training session, "The major goal of the master class was nothing short of ambitious – to traverse the intricate landscapes of narrative expression. In an era where storytelling has become both a timeless art and a contemporary dynamism, Olha Sushkevych posed a compelling inquiry: What differentiates a singular, monolithic narrative from the rich tapestry of poly storytelling, where multiple narratives converge and entwine? It is a question that resonates deeply with the students and scholars of English philology, who understand that the mere turn of a page can lead to the discovery of profound truths about the human experience".

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